300,000 People in the Path of Himalayan Disasters as Building Booms

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At least 300,000 people in parts of the Himalayan region could now be living in the path of potential disasters, a new study suggests. The researchers say the true number could be much higher, because they only studied one territory, not neighboring areas facing similar risks.

Nine researchers from the UK, Nepal, and India looked at land up to 50 kilometers downstream from Himalayan rivers, as well as around 1,360 **glacial lakes**. They found major development there: more tourism facilities, more **infrastructure**, and more real estate.

Pokhara, a major tourism hub at the foot of the Himalayas, shows the pattern clearly. It has grown significantly over the past 30 years to cater for a huge increase in visitors. Mayor Dhana Raj Acharya says it is a huge challenge to deal with the risk from the Seti Gandaki River, which flows from the Annapurna mountain range right through the city. Many old buildings stand just 5 meters from the river banks, he says, despite new rules requiring them to be further away. "Where we move them, and how we do that, is the real challenge."

To the north, the world-renowned Annapurna **trekking** region has also seen many more **settlements** along river banks, some hit by recent floods and landslides. Phurpa Chhiring Lama, who runs a homestay there, says normally all of his 20 rooms would be full at this time of year, the peak **trekking** season, but now only five are. "We have been doing this business for more than 40 years, but we've never seen this kind of disaster."

Krishna Gauchan, whose hotel stands close to the glacier-fed Modi river, worries the river could flood if the glacier collapses or a glacial lake bursts. Geographer Khagendra Poudel says tourism investors promote some of these spots without factoring in the risks, and the same is happening in parts of north India's Himalayan valleys, which host major pilgrimages. Laxman Subedi, president of the Hotel Association Pokhara, admits tourism businesses expanded "without any proper planning" and were promoted "haphazardly." "By the time disasters hit, it is too late," he says.

It is not just tourism: the regions around the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli rivers have seen a big rise in **hydropower** plants. The study was carried out before August's mass floods in Nepal, which left more than 1,400 people dead and thousands missing, and more recently flooding along the Budhi Gandaki river on 11 October damaged 200 houses, swept away five bridges, and left five people missing. "As river valleys become increasingly populated, development decisions being made today will shape disaster risk for decades to come," warns the study's lead author, University of Leeds glaciologist C Scott Watson.

Word Treasure

glacial lakes -- Lakes formed by meltwater near a glacier, a large slow-moving mass of ice.

infrastructure -- The basic systems a place needs to work, such as roads, bridges, and power supplies.

settlements -- Places where people live and build homes, from small villages to towns.

hydropower -- Electricity made by using the force of flowing or falling water.

trekking -- Walking a long distance through mountains or wild countryside, often over several days.

Background you need

The Himalayas are a very high mountain range, and rivers fed by glaciers flow down from them through valleys where people live and visit.

A glacial lake is a lake formed by meltwater near a glacier, and if it bursts or a glacier collapses, the water can rush downstream.

When hotels, homes, and power plants are built close to river banks, more people and buildings stand in the way of floods and landslides.

Planning where to build, and how far from a river, can therefore shape how safe a valley is for years to come.

Break it down

LEAD: At least 300,000 people in parts of the Himalayan region could now be living in the path of potential disasters, a new study suggests.

KEY EVENT: Rapid development along Himalayan rivers and glacial lakes has put more people in harm's way.

+- WHO: Nine researchers from the UK, Nepal, and India studied the area.

+- WHAT: More tourism facilities, infrastructure, real estate, settlements, and hydropower plants near rivers and around 1,360 glacial lakes.

+- WHERE: Land up to 50 kilometers downstream from Himalayan rivers, including Pokhara and the Annapurna trekking region.

EVIDENCE: Pokhara has grown over 30 years; many old buildings stand 5 meters from river banks; some Annapurna settlements were hit by floods and landslides; and flooding along the Budhi Gandaki river damaged 200 houses.

WARNING: The study's lead author warns that today's development decisions will shape disaster risk for decades to come.

OPEN QUESTION: The article does not say where at-risk buildings will be moved, or how that will be done.

Why it matters

Building homes, hotels, and power plants in beautiful but risky valleys can put whole communities in danger when floods or landslides strike. The choices made about where to build today will decide how safe those valleys are for decades.

Test what you remember

1. **At least how many people could now be living in the path of potential disasters, according to the study?**
   - (A) 50,000
   - (B) 1,400
   - (C) 1,360
   - (D) 300,000
2. **How many researchers carried out the study?**
   - (A) Nine
   - (B) Twenty
   - (C) Five
   - (D) Forty
3. **Which river flows through Pokhara and poses a risk the mayor calls a huge challenge?**
   - (A) The Modi river
   - (B) The Budhi Gandaki river
   - (C) The Trishuli river
   - (D) The Seti Gandaki River
4. **How far from the river banks do many old buildings in Pokhara stand?**
   - (A) 5 meters
   - (B) 50 kilometers
   - (C) 30 years away
   - (D) 20 rooms away
5. **How many of Phurpa Chhiring Lama's 20 rooms are full now, at the peak trekking season?**
   - (A) Five
   - (B) Twenty
   - (C) Nine
   - (D) Forty
6. **What did flooding along the Budhi Gandaki river on 11 October do?**
   - (A) It built 200 new houses
   - (B) It moved Pokhara 5 meters from the river
   - (C) It filled all 20 rooms of a homestay
   - (D) It damaged 200 houses, swept away five bridges, and left five people missing

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: D 4: A 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Mayor Dhana Raj Acharya of Pokhara: He says dealing with the risk from the Seti Gandaki River is a huge challenge, and asks where old buildings near the banks would be moved and how.

2. Phurpa Chhiring Lama, homestay owner: He says he has run his business for more than 40 years but has never seen this kind of disaster.

3. Laxman Subedi, president of the Hotel Association Pokhara: He admits tourism businesses expanded without any proper planning and were promoted haphazardly, and says by the time disasters hit, it is too late.

4. C Scott Watson, the study's lead author: He warns that as river valleys become more populated, today's development decisions will shape disaster risk for decades to come.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):